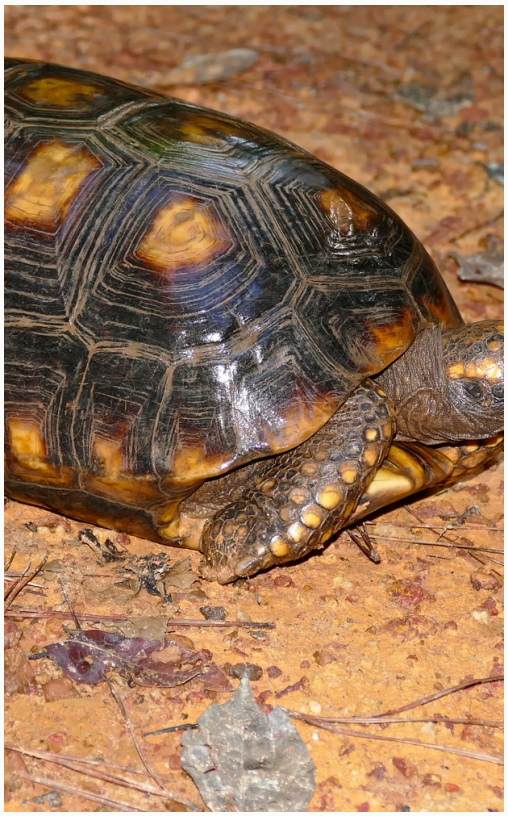
YELLOW-FOOT TORTOISE

Chelonoidis denticulatus



Think About This

When the season is wrong, do you push or wait?

What can I see or hear?

Yellow-orange scales on legs and head, dark domed shell, broad jaws. Strong sense of smell — it tracks ripe fruit through dense forest.

Where does it live, and why?

Amazon rainforest floor — wettest of the South American tortoises. Needs constant humidity and leaf litter to keep from drying out.

How does it send messages?

Head-bobbing between males in courtship and combat. Subtle tongue and posture cues. Females less demonstrative than males.

What does it do when something changes?

Tucks deep into shell. In flood, climbs to higher ground. In dry stretches, holes up and waits — fruit is the signal to come out.

How does it learn?

Memorizes fruit-tree locations across a wide home range. Follows seasonal fruit fall. Recognizes individual keepers.

How does it have babies?

Lays 4 to 12 eggs in a shallow nest, covered with leaves. Around 5 month incubation. Hatchlings independent at hatch.

What are the limits?

Lifespan 50 to 60 years. Drier or cooler climates kill them. Needs varied diet with cycled fruit and animal protein — never greens alone.

What does this teach us?

A rainforest animal moves with the rain. Wait for the season instead of fighting against it.